

The Role of Brand Personality in Charitable Giving: An Assessment and Validation

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Marketing concepts such as corporate identity, image, and branding are important strategies for nonprofit organizations. In particular, brand personality has been advocated by practitioners but has not been empirically investigated in the nonprofit context. According to social exchange theory and trust, the authors argue that nonprofit stakeholders perceive nonprofit organizations at an abstract level because of the organizations' intangibility and social ideals. This study develops and refines a parsimonious measure of brand personality specifically for the nonprofit context. The authors conduct a series of six multimethod studies of nonprofit stakeholders to validate the role of brand personality in nonprofit organizations. The results yield four dimensions of brand personality for nonprofits: integrity, nurturance, sophistication, and ruggedness. Thus, current and potential donors ascribe personality traits to nonprofit organizations and differentiate between nonprofits on the basis of the organizations' personality. Finally, nonprofit brand personality may influence potential donors' likelihood to contribute.

Keywords: *nonprofit marketing; brand personality; measurement; social exchange; charitable giving*

Since their introduction in the United States in the late 1700s, nonprofit organizations have provided many critical services (e.g., education, arts, social services; Hawks 1997). Several recent trends have renewed interest in nonprofit marketing. First, substantial reductions in government funding have placed pressure on nonprofit organizations to finance their operations through private donations (Bendapudi, Singh, and Bendapudi 1996). Second, the number of nonprofit organizations in the United States has substantially increased. Currently, there are more than 1.23 million nonprofit organizations in the United States, compared with only 12,000 such organizations in 1940 (Boris 1999). Third, individual or household giving has not kept pace with the increased number of nonprofit organizations (Sargeant 1999), which has resulted in increased competition for donations. Finally, a new generation of donors has emerged that increasingly perceives the nonprofit sector as a "big business" that should be held accountable for the effectiveness of its operations and

services, as should any other operation with access to billions of dollars in monetary contributions and volunteer hours (Blum 2002; Morley, Vinson, and Hatry 2001).

Given these trends, marketing strategy has become a fundamental tool in the nonprofit sector. Indeed, both the application of marketing concepts to nonprofit organizations and the understanding of donor behavior have been discussed for more than three decades (e.g., Arnett, German, and Hunt 2003; Burnett and Wood 1988; Kotler and Levy 1969; Mindak and Bybee 1971). Nonprofit organizations have aggressively pursued strategies such as market segmentation (see Harvey 1990; Nichols 1991), relationship and database marketing (Arnett et al. 2003; Nichols 1995; Peltier, Schibrowsky, and Schultz 2002), branding (Nucifora 1998; Tapp 1996; Wray 1994), and distinctive and positive image development (Grounds and Harkness 1998).

Although these strategic issues are important to nonprofit researchers and practitioners, exploration of the unique nature of nonprofits and how key stakeholders differentiate, evaluate, and choose to enter into a relationship with such organizations is an important and under-researched area. Much of the research in relationship marketing, and almost all of the research in branding, has focused on for-profit firms. For example, Arnett et al. (2003) stated that "much of the research on relationship marketing success has examined relationships that (1) are primarily economic in nature, (2) involved business-to-business marketing, and (3) involved for-profit firms" (p. 89). Similarly, research conducted in branding and brand personality has been based on for-profit brands.

We contend that brand personality differentiates nonprofit organizations in a competitive charitable market and thus is beneficial to nonprofit practitioners and researchers. Our examination of brand personality in the nonprofit context aims to extend prior research on both brand personality and charitable giving (e.g., Burnett 1981; Cermak, File, and Prince 1994; Harvey 1990). Of key interest to our study is the examination of whether and how brand personality manifests in the nonprofit sector. Thus, we aim to answer the following questions: (1) Do nonprofit organizations possess brand personalities? (2) If they do, what kind of personalities are they? (3) Are nonprofit brand personalities related the charitable giving intentions? and (4) How can brand personalities help nonprofit marketers?

Because of the intangible, service-oriented nature of nonprofit organizations, we posit that social exchange and trust play an important role in consumers' decisions of whether to donate money, time, or in-kind goods or services to such organizations. Thus, in this context, brand personality and its dimensions may not be consistent with previous research on brand personality. The purpose of this research is to investigate the applicability, measurement, and validation of brand personality in nonprofit

organizations. Thus, our objectives are threefold: first, we examine the nature of exchange, trust, and brand personality in the nonprofit context. Second, on the basis of a series of qualitative and quantitative studies among nonprofit stakeholders, we refine and develop a parsimonious measure of brand personality for nonprofit organizations. Third, we assess the predictive validity of nonprofit brand personality on consumers' likelihood to contribute, and we discuss the implications of our findings for both theory and nonprofit marketers.

CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATION

Charitable Giving: Key Nonprofit Stakeholders

In marketing, research on charitable giving has focused primarily on the study of donor characteristics (e.g., Cermak et al. 1994; Harvey 1990). However, several authors (e.g., Burnett and Wood 1988) have developed models of donor behavior that incorporate the impact of antecedent states such as personal traits (e.g., self-esteem, empathy, guilt), demographic characteristics (e.g., age, gender, education), situational factors, and perceived rewards on evaluation and behavioral intentions (i.e., gifts of cash, time, goods, or donor loyalty). Of particular interest to this study are nonprofit stakeholders' evaluation of and intention to give to nonprofit organizations.

As do their counterparts in government, public, and private institutions, nonprofit organizations have many stakeholders with whom they work on an ongoing basis. The two largest groups are the people who contribute to nonprofit organizations and the beneficiaries of the services that the organizations provide. Often, the two groups overlap because people who contribute also may benefit. For example, a person may contribute time or money to an organization such as the Nature Conservancy and also benefit from his or her efforts to save environmental resources. Employees are another group of stakeholders who are crucial to nonprofit organizations' success. In addition to these stakeholders, the relationships between nonprofit organizations, for-profit firms, and government agencies also are important. Partnerships between these stakeholder groups provide a means to address complex social problems, with the ultimate goal of helping nonprofits' beneficiaries.

In this study, we focus on current and potential contributors of time, money, and in-kind goods or services to nonprofit organizations. Research on nonprofit contributors in the United States has indicated that approximately 89 percent of all households contribute monetarily to nonprofit organizations and 44 percent of adults volunteer (approximately 9 million full-time employees, valued at \$239 billion) for nonprofit organizations (Weitzman and

Jalandoni 2001). In addition, we focus on individual contributors to be consistent with prior research that measures brand personality in the for-profit sector, in which sampling is at the individual consumer level.

Social Exchange and Trust

The issues of how and why people choose to give to charity have been widely debated (Wispe 1978). The concept of charity has been examined in many diverse disciplines, including classical economics, clinical psychology, and anthropology. Thus, the theoretical underpinnings of donation behavior range from social exchange and equity theory to prosocial and helping behavior (for a review, see Burnett and Wood 1988).

From a marketing perspective, in most transactions, the nature of exchange for nonprofits differs from the more typical monetary-based exchange. The act of giving to a nonprofit organization tends to be more social than economic in nature. Thus, social exchange theory (e.g., Bagozzi 1975; Blau 1964; Homans 1958) can aid in explaining why donors give (Burnett and Wood 1988). Here, the economics of giving may be limited to benefits such as tax breaks, whereas the social benefits of giving can be far more important and range from personal satisfaction and self-worth to humanitarianism and spiritualism (Arnett et al. 2003; Cermak et al. 1994). Arnould, Price, and Zinkhan (2004) referred to *generalized reciprocity* as donors' choosing to give of their own time, money, or services with little economic expectations in return. Thus, nonprofit organizations tend to emphasize the *social* benefits of giving (i.e., social approval, respect, and humanitarianism). This is not to imply that for-profit organizations do not focus on social benefits. However, the social benefits of giving to a nonprofit organization are more salient than those of giving to for-profits. Because social benefits have been deemed to be important in the nonprofit setting (Arnett et al. 2003), it follows that to develop potentially successful and *trustworthy* relationships, nonprofit organizations must be able to identify and communicate benefits to their stakeholders.

Social exchange theory has often been used in the relationship and service marketing literature as the theoretical foundation for developing trust (Arnett et al. 2003; Berry and Parasuraman 1991; Doney and Cannon 1997; Dwyer, Schurr, and Oh 1987; Morgan and Hunt 1994; Smith and Barclay 1997). Trust in marketing has been defined as "a willingness to rely on an exchange partner in whom one has confidence" (Moorman, Deshpandé, and Zaltman 1993:82). Morgan and Hunt (1994) built on this definition and conceptualized trust as "existing when one party has confidence in an exchange partner's *reliability* and *integrity*" (p. 23, emphasis added). This suggests that reliability and integrity play a central role when current and potential donors evaluate nonprofit organizations because of the

intangibility of the services that nonprofits offer and the social nature of exchange in the donor-nonprofit relationship. Current and potential donors must be able to trust that the nonprofit organization will use their donations of time, money, or in-kind goods or services responsibly. Thus, these stakeholders may search for cues that symbolize reliability and integrity. A cue that many nonprofit marketers have recently focused on is the nonprofit *brand* (Tapp 1996). We now discuss branding in terms of nonprofit organizations' corporate identity, image, and personality.

Developing a Nonprofit Brand

The use of brands as a "distinguishing name and/or symbol (such as a logo, trademark, or package design)" (D. A. Aaker 1991:7) continues to evolve. Initially, brands were used to identify and distinguish between specific manufacturers of consumer goods. Today, brands are widely recognized as important vehicles for differentiating among services, people, ideas, and organizations. Examples of the increasing proliferation of brands include the branding of previously invisible components and ingredients, such as Intel Inside and Splenda, and the branding of government entities and destinations (O'Shaughnessy and O'Shaughnessy 2000). Moreover, the days of a brand's power being viewed as relevant only to tangible goods are over (Berry 2000).

Nonprofits are primarily service organizations that desire to help people. Whether it is finding a way to cure a disease (i.e., American Cancer Society), to protect the environment (i.e., Sierra Club), or to promote artistic endeavors (i.e., National Endowment for the Arts), in general, nonprofit organizations do not offer tangible products for sale but rather offer intangible services and ideals. Because nonprofits are primarily services, the *organization* offering the service becomes the focal point for consumers (Berry 2000). "With services, the company [not the product] is the primary brand . . . [and] brand development is crucial in services, given the inherent difficulty in differentiating products that lack physical differences (Zeithaml 1981) and the intense competition within service markets" (Berry 2000:128-29). Thus, because of the vast number of nonprofit organizations and the increased competition for donation dollars, it follows that development of a strong nonprofit brand occurs at the organizational level and may provide a distinct competitive advantage.

Previous research has explored a series of concepts related to the meaning, value, and effective use of brands. *Brand equity* refers to the inherent value of a name, symbol, or product/service design. Although brand equity is often examined in the context of for-profit organizations, it also can be viewed as the value of the name, symbol, or perceived service offerings of a nonprofit organization,

such as the American Red Cross or the American Heart Association (Burnett 2002).

Because the organization is the central focus in services and nonprofit marketing, an important component in building brand equity is the development of a strong corporate identity. *Corporate identity* is the collective way that an organization identifies itself. In other words, it is the ideal image that an organization wants its public to hold (Johnson and Zinkhan 1990). Corporate identity involves not only the mere recognition of a name, symbol, or other distinguishing feature but also knowledge of what the company represents or the functions that it performs. As Johnson and Zinkhan (1990) noted, "The company articulates through its words, symbols, and actions, what it is, what it stands for, and what it does" (p. 110). Although previous descriptions of corporate identity have focused generally on consumer goods, it is important for nonprofit organizations to develop a corporate identity because people who elect to donate need to understand the functions of the nonprofit organization before they commit or entrust their resources to it. Thus, in accordance to social exchange theory, donors must be able to understand the social benefits of contributing to a nonprofit organization.

Although organizations strive to project a strong and positive corporate identity, people's *perception* of this identity is critical. Thus, corporate image is the overall impression that various stakeholders have of the company (Johnson and Zinkhan 1990). Researchers in marketing have recognized the importance of the "human need to simplify buying decisions by creating symbolic representations" (Stern, Zinkhan, and Jaju 2001:201) and thus have conducted image research for many years. A person's image of an organization can be viewed as a preliminary heuristic for deciding whether to become involved with the organization. A negative corporate image discourages consumers from becoming involved (Webb, Green, and Brashear 2000), whereas a positive image provides an impetus and rationale for involvement. Thus, the image that key stakeholders have of a nonprofit organization may influence their intent to give money, time, or in-kind services.

In summary, because the characteristics and benefits of becoming involved with a nonprofit organization are largely intangible, branding can facilitate a donor's understanding and support of a charity (Dixon 1997; Sargeant 1999). Indeed, many nonprofit organizations practice various components of branding. As Tapp (1996) pointed out,

Charities do not describe much of what they do as "branding"; [however,] organizations have long been concerned with maintaining a consistent style and tone of voice and conducting periodic reviews of both policies and actions to ensure that a consistent *personality* is projected to important stakeholders. (P. 335, emphasis added)

Nonprofit Brand Personality

A closely related concept to corporate image is that of corporate personality. Indeed, some researchers have used the word *personality* to define corporate image. For example, Sethi (quoted in Stern et al. 2001:212) defines corporate image as the "image of the corporate personality held in the minds of various publics." Thus, we argue that research in brand personality that has predominantly focused on for-profit consumer products provides an important starting point for understanding brand personality both at the corporate or organizational level and of nonprofit organizations.

Jennifer Aaker (1997) defined brand personality as "the set of human characteristics associated with a brand" (p. 347). To develop a conceptual framework to measure the personality of consumer brands, Aaker adapted the work of personality researchers in psychology who examined the "Big Five," or five-factor, model (John 1990; McCrae and Costa 1989; Norman 1963; Tupes and Christal 1958). This stream of research provides a means for measuring the perceptions of a brand, a method for differentiating a brand from its competitors, and a common denominator for marketing brands across market segments and subcultures (J. L. Aaker 1997). Aaker used the personality trait approach to study the perceived human characteristics of brands and measure the valence of these traits among subjects. The end result of Aaker's study was a measure of brand personality that consisted of 42 traits and five dimensions: sincerity, excitement, competence, sophistication, and ruggedness. Follow-up analyses indicated that this five-factor structure was a reliable and valid measure of the symbolic attributes of brand personality across product categories and of the brands within a particular category (J. L. Aaker 1997).

In subsequent research, Jennifer Aaker (1999) used her brand personality dimensions in two different experiments to examine the self-expressive use of brands and how a person's self-concept and situational influences affect brand preference. The results indicate that consumers' preference for brands that had personality traits consistent with their own self-schema was moderated by their degree of "self-monitoring" (J. L. Aaker 1999:47) or propensity to conform to what was deemed socially acceptable in different situations. Jennifer Aaker (2000) also examined the accessibility and diagnosticity of persuasive associations in a series of experiments in a cross-cultural setting. She determined that both situational accessibility and cultural differences influence individual perceptions of the personality of a brand.

The specific dimensions of brand personality have been examined among French (Ferrandi, Valette-Florence, and Fine-Falcy 2000), Japanese, and Spanish (Aaker, Benet-Martinez, and Garolera 2001) consumers. Table 1 summarizes the dimensions that have been found in studies of

TABLE 1
Brand Personality Dimensions:
Similarities and Differences With Aaker's (1997) Study

<i>Author(s)</i>	<i>Product/Brand</i>	<i>Sample (N)</i>	<i>Aaker's (1997) Dimensions</i>	<i>Similar Dimensions</i>	<i>Different Dimensions</i>
Aaker (1997)	Four product groups/ 37 brands	National. N = 631	Sincerity, sophistication, ruggedness, competence, and excitement		
Ferrandi, Valette-Florence, and Fine-Faley (2000)	Three product groups/ 12 brands	Convenience (students) France N = 246		Sincerity	Dynamism, femininity, robustness, and conviviality
Aaker (2000)	Cruise line Cologne	Convenience (graduate students in United States and Tokyo). N = 74		Sincerity, sophistication, competence, and excitement	Peacefulness
		Mail intercept (at two West Coast grocery stores). N = 198			
Aaker, Benel-Martinez, and Carolera (2001)	Study 1: Four product groups/ 25 brands	Japanese national mail panel. N = 1,495		Excitement, sincerity, sophistication, and competence	Peacefulness
	Study 2: Four product groups/ 25 brands	Japanese graduate students/U.S. Japanese exchange students. N = 90		Excitement, sincerity, sophistication, and competence	Peacefulness
	Study 3: Four product groups/ 25 brands	Spanish national mail panel. N = 692		Excitement, sincerity, and sophistication	Peacefulness and passion

brand personality. Using an exploratory approach, Ferrandi et al. (2000) found partial structural and semantic correspondence with Jennifer Aaker's (1997) scale. They reduced the number of traits from 42 to 33 and found five dimensions: sincerity, dynamism, femininity, robustness, and conviviality. As we depict in Table 1, sincerity among French respondents was the only common dimension that Ferrandi et al. (2000) found with Aaker's (1997) study. The dimensions that Jennifer Aaker (2000) and Aaker et al. (2001) found among Japanese consumers were more similar to Jennifer Aaker's (1997) original study: excitement, competence, sincerity, and sophistication. However, peacefulness emerged as a separate dimension in both studies using Japanese samples. Finally, whereas the common dimensions found among Spanish consumers were excitement, sincerity, and sophistication, peacefulness and passion also emerged among this sample (Aaker et al. 2001). Thus, although specific dimensions, such as peacefulness, conviviality, and passion, have occurred in one or more specific cultures, previous replications and extensions of brand personality have found a relatively consistent set of dimensions (i.e., sincerity, excitement, sophistication, and competence). Moreover, previous studies have focused on exploring the dimensions of brand personality in for-profit products and have examined brand personality in cross-cultural settings.

To our knowledge, previous research has not examined the extension of brand personality to the nonprofit sector. Thus, we seek to integrate existing knowledge of brand personality in the for-profit sector with social exchange theory and trust to identify the specific dimensions of brand personality in nonprofit organizations. First, we recognize that nonprofit organizations are primarily intangible services and thus are themselves the focal point for consumers. Second, because the benefits of giving to nonprofits are primarily social rather than economic, we believe that the salient dimensions of nonprofit brand personality reflect the social nature of nonprofits and the importance of trust in terms of reliability and integrity.

METHOD

Because prior research has not examined brand personality specifically in the context of nonprofit organizations, we developed a six-study, multimethod design. The first three studies used a discovery approach and consisted of three qualitative methods: nominal groups, focus groups, and depth interviews of current donors and nonprofit professionals. We designed each qualitative study to explore two questions: (1) Do nonprofits have personalities? and (2) If they do, what are the contents and dimensions of the personalities? After we incorporated the results of these three studies, we conducted a fourth and fifth study among current donors to explore quantitatively the measurement

of brand personality and to determine its dimensions among nonprofit organizations in a parsimonious and reliable manner. Finally, we conducted a sixth study of potential donors to assess the predictive validity of our measure by examining the effect of nonprofit brand personality on intent to donate.

QUALITATIVE STUDIES

We employed a multimethod approach that used a modified focus group forum, traditional focus groups, and depth interviews. First, we conducted modified focus group sessions (i.e., nominal groups). We then conducted two traditional focus groups and 18 depth interviews. The participants in these studies were students, working professionals, and nonprofit practitioners. All studies incorporated the use of individual "worksheets," were audiotaped, and were subsequently transcribed.

Stimuli Selection

To enhance the scope and comprehensiveness of the qualitative research, we believed that it was important to select nonprofit organizations that might represent a broad spectrum of personality types. First, we chose three major classifications of nonprofit organizations from *The National Taxonomy of Exempt Entities* (American Association of Fundraising Council 2001): health, environment/rights, and arts/humanities. These classifications represent the largest groups or segments of nonprofit organizations in the United States (excluding education and religious charities), have the same requirements for filing with the Internal Revenue Service, and are required to make their financial information available to the public (American Association of Fundraising Council 2001). From these classifications, we selected specific nonprofits that were somewhat homogeneous in size, scope, and financial structure. Additional criteria that we used to select the nonprofit organizations were that they were well-known; national in scope; and had the potential to identify, attract, and retain donors (see Webb et al. 2000). A faculty panel reviewed the final selections to provide an initial assessment of each organization's national scope and distinctiveness. Table 2 provides a list of the selected nonprofit organizations (by classification).

Study 1: Student Donor Focus Groups

In the first qualitative study, we used a modified form of the focus group, termed a *nominal grouping session*. This method allows for participation of larger groups in the exploration of a construct and incorporates independent responses that are completed before group discussions.

TABLE 2
Stimuli Brands

<i>Health</i>	<i>Environment/Rights</i>	<i>Arts/Humanities</i>
American Cancer Society	Sierra Club	Literacy Council of America
United Cerebral Palsy	Save the Whales	Public Broadcasting Services
National Kidney Foundation	National Audubon Society	Southern Dance Works
March of Dimes	Greenpeace	National Academy of Fine Arts
AIDS Society	National Rifle Association	National Symphony Association
Arthritis Foundation	American Botanical Society	National Historical Society

Before we facilitated the discussion with the entire group, each participant was provided with a worksheet that listed the six nonprofit organizations in each of the three classifications (health, environment, or arts and human services). Participants were instructed to select two nonprofit organizations from each of the three classifications and list at least five adjectives to describe their choice "as if it were a person." This procedure was followed by an open discussion.

Sample. The participants for the first two nominal groups were junior and senior undergraduate students who were enrolled in the business school of a large, public, southeastern university and who were active donors to some type of nonprofit organization in the past 12 months (78%). Research has shown that during the past few years, more young adults are participating in charitable giving (Marchetti 2003). Of the participants, 56 percent were male, 44 percent were female, and 96 percent were between 20 and 23 years of age. The purpose of this initial step was to test whether donors could ascribe personality traits to nonprofit organizations and to obtain initial feedback on the specific choices of nonprofit organizations in each category.

Results. The most frequently selected nonprofit organizations provided initial insight into student donors' perceptions of the most well-known organizations. The organizations included the American Cancer Society, March of Dimes, National Rifle Association, Greenpeace, National Academy of Fine Arts, and the Public Broadcasting Service (PBS). Each participant was asked to use at least five adjectives to describe the personality of his or her selected nonprofit. The distinctiveness of the most frequently mentioned words suggested that student donors attribute distinctive traits to nonprofit organizations. Many of the descriptive terms resembled those used in Jennifer Aaker's (1997) study of consumer brands. However, participants also frequently mentioned words such as *loving*, *kind*, *caring*, *helpful*, *reliable*, and *compassionate*, which were not frequently identified in previous research. This implies the possibility of additional personality traits among perceptions of nonprofit organizations.

Study 2: Community Donor Focus Groups

At this stage of discovery, it was important to recruit nonstudent participants who represented different demographic profiles and provided greater depth and breadth of discussions of nonprofit brand personality. In addition, in the marketing and nonprofit literature, Weitzman and Jalandoni (2001) have identified age as an important factor in people's motivation, ability, and opportunity to become involved with nonprofits. Participants were asked to select two of the six nonprofit organizations from each classification and to describe the organizations with at least five adjectives as if they were a person. Again, a discussion followed the written exercise.

Sample. We recruited participants for two separate focus groups. One focus group was recruited through a notice that was posted on a board in an office complex in a medium-sized city. The other focus group sought recruits from an announcement in the monthly newsletter of a retirement community in a smaller city. The reward for participation in both groups was a meal and door prizes. These efforts resulted in 16 respondents. Of participants in both focus groups, the majority were female (75%), ranged in age from 30 to older than 60, and were contributors to a wide variety of nonprofit organizations (100%).

Results. In general, the community donor focus groups selected the same nonprofit organizations and used a similar list of descriptive adjectives as the student donor sample. Participants also used words such as *caring*, *kind*, and *compassionate*, which further implied additional personality traits uniquely associated with nonprofits. In addition, the community donors identified personality characteristics that did not emerge in the student donor focus groups. The participants appeared to be concerned with the efficiency or effectiveness of nonprofit organizations, and thus words such as *organized*, *reputable*, *forward-thinking*, and *reflective* emerged. Participants embellished the symbolic traits typically associated with brand personality studies with additional reliability and integrity aspects (i.e., trustworthiness) that might be related to the

efficient use of funds and the effective provision of services. We pursued these findings further by conducting the next qualitative step: depth interviews.

Study 3: Depth Interviews: Donors and Nonprofit Professionals

The depth interviews began with participants filling out the same worksheet as was used for the focus groups. After participants spent a few moments describing the personality of two nonprofits, we used a semistructured protocol for in-depth discussions that lasted a little more than 1 hour.

Sample. We conducted a total of 18 depth interviews. In addition to motivation and ability to contribute, we introduced an additional criterion for recruiting: at least half of the people interviewed must be professional nonprofit practitioners. We did this to explore perceptions of brand personality among nonprofit organization employees. Of the 18 interviewees, the majority were between the ages of 50 and 59 (51%), were female (61%), and had personally contributed to nonprofit organizations (78%). For participants who were nonprofit practitioners, personal contributions were independent of professional employment. The nonprofit practitioners were also either senior vice presidents or executive directors, who had been in the nonprofit arena for an average of 20 years. Each interview was audiotaped and subsequently transcribed.

Results. After careful review of the transcripts and the participants' worksheets, we concluded that the depth interviews further supported the unique brand personality attributes for nonprofits. For example, one respondent mentioned, "I would say that particular nonprofit, as a person, is big and tough, the bully on the block. However, they have vision for where they want to go." Another respondent mentioned, "When thinking of the nonprofit as a person, I saw someone who was caring, aggressive, passionate."

In addition, the importance of the reliability and integrity of a nonprofit organization emerged just as it had in the community donor focus groups. One interviewee who was a nonprofit practitioner commented, "Volunteers today demand accountability. They want to see outcome measures." Another respondent stated, "There is a tremendous pressure on nonprofits regarding accountability where our boards want sound cash management and financial projections." The importance of integrity also emerged from the interviewees who were *not* practitioners. These people repeatedly emphasized that they "wanted to know where their money was going." As we discussed previously, it appears that trust in a nonprofit to manage contributions responsibly is important not only among donors but also

TABLE 3
New Items Generated From Qualitative Studies

<i>Thoughtfulness</i>	<i>Integrity</i>	<i>Reliability</i>
Loving	Reputable	Cost-effective
Compassionate	Committed to public good	Financially stable
Kind	Purposeful	
Helpful	Accessible	
Caring	Long-term orientation	

among nonprofit professionals. In summary, participants stressed nonprofit organizations' service orientation, need to help others, and trustworthiness in soliciting and using funds to achieve their mission.

Summary of the Qualitative Studies

Overall, some of the terms that participants used to describe nonprofit organizations were similar to those used for consumer brands (J. L. Aaker 1997). Sincerity, excitement, competence, sophistication, and ruggedness all were viable dimensions for describing nonprofit organizations. However, two other important findings based on the qualitative studies emerged: (1) the social importance of nonprofits being kind, caring, and compassionate, and (2) the trustworthiness of nonprofits.

The new descriptive words we discovered in our study's qualitative phase are related to the salience of social exchange and trust in the nonprofit context (see Table 3). We organize these descriptive words under three new dimensions: thoughtfulness (loving, compassionate, kind, helpful, and caring), integrity (reputable, committed to the public good, purposeful, accessible, and long-term orientation), and reliability (cost-effective and financially stable).

QUANTITATIVE STUDIES

There were two primary objectives of the quantitative phase of the research: (1) to examine empirically the dimensions of brand personality in the nonprofit context and (2) to assess the reliability and validity of the dimensions among nonprofit donors. We conducted the research in the quantitative phase in a two-step process. First, we conducted exploratory factor analyses among faculty, staff (Study 4), and student (Study 5) donors to develop parsimonious brand personality measures for nonprofit organizations. Second, we conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (Study 6) among a more nationally representative sample, which was designed to reflect the U.S. population along several demographic and donor characteristics.

For this quantitative phase, we chose samples to reflect a range of existing and potential donors for nonprofit orga-

nizations. Initial efforts (Studies 4 and 5) focused on two convenience samples (faculty/staff and students) that represented current and future donors to nonprofit organizations. The use of these two samples enabled us to determine and cross-check the dimensions of brand personality among two separate samples independently. Additional efforts (Study 6) focused on assessing and confirming the generalizability of the dimensions among a nationally representative sample of potential donors patterned after the national study that Jennifer Aaker (1997) conducted.

In each quantitative study, we took care to maintain consistency with the nonprofit stakeholders included in the sample. Classification questions enabled us to ascertain respondents' involvement with nonprofit organizations. All samples exhibited high levels of experience or current involvement (more than 70%), as evidenced by the high percentage of respondents who reported committing money, time, or goods or services to nonprofit organizations in the past 12 months.

Studies 4 and 5: Exploratory Analysis of Factor Structure

Stimuli. We used the same nonprofit classifications that we employed in the qualitative studies in Study 4 (health, environment/rights, and arts/humanities). However, each product category was represented by only one exemplar brand (i.e., March of Dimes, Greenpeace, or PBS). These brands were the most salient and the most frequently chosen in their category from the original choices provided in the qualitative phase. The use of exemplar nonprofit brands was important to minimize respondent fatigue. Each respondent was asked to evaluate how descriptive the brand personality traits were for one of these three organizations.

We selected a separate set of exemplar brands in Study 5 to increase the generalizability of the results. We examined a total of five nonprofit organizations, one from each of the top five product categories of nonprofit organizations in the National Taxonomy of Exempt Entities: arts, culture, and humanities; health related; environmental; human services; and public and societal benefit (Urban Institute 2002). After reviewing a list of the organizations, we used the top organization in terms of revenue from each of the five categories (Jones 2002) to ensure that the organizations selected were national in scope, were representative of their category, and provided a diverse and recognizable set of stimuli. The specific organizations were Habitat for Humanity, American Heart Association, Nature Conservancy, and American Red Cross. We randomly assigned each participant to one of the organizations and asked them to evaluate its brand personality.

Samples. The sampling frame for Study 4 included full-time faculty and staff from a large, public, southeastern

university. Surveys were distributed through campus mail, and we used a drawing for a monetary prize as an incentive. Of the 1,380 surveys distributed, 403 were returned, for a response rate of approximately 29 percent. On the basis of the criteria of percentage of completion, two independent reviewers excluded 17 of the returned surveys, which yielded an effective response rate of 27.2 percent, or 376 usable responses.

As a whole, the sample for this quantitative phase was between the ages of 25 and 54 (77%), female (64%), relatively educated (47% held a graduate degree), and middle-class (64% earned between \$20,000 and \$74,999); it also consisted predominantly of staff (66%) rather than faculty. The vast majority of respondents (89.3%) reported involvement with a nonprofit organization in the past 12 months.

The sample for Study 5 consisted of 355 undergraduate business majors from two large public universities. Students were made aware of the survey through an electronic bulletin board used by large introductory marketing classes; participation was on a voluntary basis. Of the participants, 54.2 percent were male and 45.6 percent were female; their average age was between 18 and 24 (95.8%), which we expected in this population. We asked participants two questions to assess their degree of involvement with nonprofit organizations. The first asked about prior experience with nonprofit organizations on a scale of 1 (*none*) to 5 (*a lot*), of which 69 percent of participants indicated their experience level of 3 or higher. The second asked about the number of nonprofit organizations the respondents had been involved with in the past 12 months. Approximately 45.1 percent indicated their involvement with between two and five organizations. Thus, as a whole, the sample had experience with, and at least some prior involvement with, nonprofit organizations.

Measures. We developed survey instruments for Studies 4 and 5. We included a qualifying question in the surveys to ensure that respondents were involved with one or more nonprofit organizations in the past 12 months. As we previously mentioned, an additional question inquired about how many different organizations participants might have contributed to and in what form (i.e., time, money, or in-kind goods or services).

Another section of the survey began with 54 items that we designed to assess brand personality. We combined Jennifer Aaker's (1997) original 42 items with 12 newly developed descriptors on the basis of the results of the qualitative studies. As we show in Table 3, the new items were added to address two important themes that emerged from the qualitative phase of our research. First, we added several items to measure the potential social nature of nonprofits. Second, we added items to capture more precisely the trust aspects (i.e., integrity and reliability) of nonprofit organizations that were identified in the qualitative work.

Results: Exploratory factor analysis. A factor analysis of the brand personality items resulted in a four-factor solution for both Studies 4 and 5, based on interpretation and a scree plot. As we show in Table 4, we retained two of Jennifer Aaker's (1997) original five factors (sophistication and ruggedness). Items for sincerity, excitement, and competence did not form distinct dimensions, and they cross-loaded on other factors. Two new factors based on the additional traits generated from the qualitative studies emerged as distinct brand personality dimensions of nonprofits: integrity and nurturance. Integrity focused on the reputation, honesty, and reliability of the organization. Nurturance focused on the extent to which a nonprofit organization was perceived to be loving, compassionate, and caring.

In summary, the factor analysis for both samples resulted in a four-factor solution of integrity, ruggedness, sophistication, and nurturance. Of the original 54 items (traits), we retained 15, which resulted in a more parsimonious measure of brand personality for nonprofit organizations.

Reliability. We found that all four of the symbolic personality dimensions demonstrate sufficient reliability (Churchill 1979; Nunnally 1979). We assessed *integrity* with five items, resulting in alpha coefficients of .86 and .91 for the student and faculty/staff samples, respectively. We measured *ruggedness* using four items that produced alpha coefficients of .87 and .84, respectively. We measured *sophistication* using three items, yielding alpha coefficients of .84 for both samples. Finally, we assessed *nurturance* with three newly developed items—loving, caring, and compassionate—that we derived from the qualitative work, which resulted in alpha coefficients of .82 and .81 for the student and faculty/staff samples, respectively.

Personality differentiation. The measures we developed in this phase were intended to differentiate the personalities of nonprofit organizations. We compared the results of a multivariate analysis of variance to assess whether the mean scores for the exemplar nonprofit brands differed across the dimensions of brand personality for the three organizations in Study 4 (see Table 5). The nonprofit organizations exhibited distinct personalities. Participants viewed PBS and March of Dimes as having more integrity than Greenpeace, which was rated as the most *rugged* and the least *nurturing* of the three organizations. Whereas PBS was viewed as the most sophisticated, March of Dimes was viewed as the most nurturing. Thus, it appears that current and potential donors not only ascribe personality traits to nonprofit organizations but also differentiate between organizations on the basis of personality. We discuss this finding further in the Discussion and Implications section.

Study 6: Confirmatory Analysis of Factor Structure

Stimuli. Before we began Study 6, we conducted a check of the exemplar brands used in Studies 4 and 5. Ninety-four people were contacted by telephone during a period of 10 days and asked about their recognition of eight brands from the same three product classifications. March of Dimes (94.4%), Greenpeace (38.9%), and PBS (88.9%) were again the most frequently identified organizations in each of their respective categories; therefore, we used them in Study 6.

Sample. Using the 2000 U.S. Bureau of the Census guidelines, we stratified the sample to represent five demographic dimensions of the U.S. population (sex, household income, age, ethnicity, and geographic location). We took this approach in an effort to contact a cross section of people who would be representative of the average U.S. household and to be consistent with Jennifer Aaker's (1997) original study, which was based on a similar national sample of individual consumers. As with each of our prior samples, we asked respondents about their involvement with any nonprofit in the past 12 months. Of the respondents, 80.3 percent indicated that they had contributed to a nonprofit during that period. Prior research has consistently shown that, on average, approximately 80 to 90 percent of U.S. households contribute to nonprofits in any given year (Weitzman and Jalandoni 2001).

Of a total of 7,952 eligible telephone numbers, the number of completed interviews was 1,029, for an effective response rate of 12.9 percent. Of the respondents, 60 percent were female, 26.8 percent had a college degree, and 17.3 percent had graduate or professional degrees. Approximately 32.7 percent of respondents reported income between \$20,000 and \$50,000, and 27.8 percent reported income between \$50,000 and \$100,000; 10.4 percent of respondents reported an income of less than \$20,000, and 11.2 percent reported an income of greater than \$100,000.

Procedure. We collected data by telephone. The contacts were identified by means of modified random digit dialing to include the 48 contiguous states. The interviewers were professionally trained and experienced in using the computer-assisted telephone interview (CATI), an automated system for contacting and interviewing that captures responses in a database during interviews. The instrument was pretested in a series of small samples (10–12), and on the basis of the results, we made refinements to it before initiating the full study. Each interview lasted approximately 12 minutes. The primary calling times were between 6:00 p.m. and 9:00 p.m., Monday through Friday. To minimize selection bias, we took the following two measures: (1) for each successful household contact, a

TABLE 4
Standardized Factor Loadings: Exploratory Factor Analysis^{a,b,c}

	Integrity		Ruggedness		Sophistication		Nurturance		Communality	
	Student (n = 355)	Faculty/Staff (n = 376)	Student (n = 355)	Faculty/Staff (n = 376)	Student (n = 355)	Faculty/Staff (n = 376)	Student (n = 355)	Faculty/Staff (n = 376)	Student (n = 355)	Faculty/Staff (n = 376)
Honest	.81	.74	-.04	-.05	-.01	.22	.19	.29	.69	.68
Reputable	.80	.86	-.04	-.04	.02	.09	.29	.17	.73	.78
Reliable	.72	.71	.14	-.08	.12	.16	.26	.38	.62	.68
Positive influence	.65	.83	.18	-.08	.13	.15	.07	.12	.48	.73
Committed	.52	.87	.08	-.02	-.03	.00	.38	.21	.42	.80
Masculine	.12	.02	.81	.77	.29	.21	.02	.04	.77	.64
Outdoorsy	.14	-.04	.81	.80	-.04	.04	-.08	-.06	.68	.65
Tough	.05	-.04	.79	.81	.16	.09	.15	.07	.67	.67
Western	-.08	-.03	.71	.74	.41	.22	.01	.08	.68	.60
Glamorous	.01	.02	.16	.19	.90	.85	-.02	.10	.84	.77
Upper class	.12	.22	.14	.18	.81	.72	-.05	-.18	.70	.63
Good-looking	.08	.14	.25	.21	.79	.78	.10	.27	.70	.75
Compassionate	.30	.48	.04	.06	.01	.02	.88	.70	.87	.72
Loving	.27	.17	.04	-.05	.10	.34	.87	.78	.84	.76
Caring	.47	.56	-.01	.14	-.14	-.10	.66	.71	.68	.85
Eigenvalue	4.6	6.0	3.3	3.1	1.4	1.0	1.0	1.5		
% of variance extracted	30.8	37.4	22.1	19.3	9.2	6.2	6.5	9.4		

a. Extraction method: principal components analysis with Varimax rotation.

b. We evaluated each brand personality item using a Likert-type scale (1 = *not at all descriptive* and 5 = *very descriptive*).

c. New items generated from the qualitative phase are shown in *italics* to differentiate them from the items retained from Aaker's (1997) work.

TABLE 5
Mean Differences in Brand Personality Dimensions Across Three Nonprofit Organizations^{a,b,c}

<i>Dependent Variable</i>	<i>df</i>	<i>F Value</i>	<i>p Value</i>	<i>PBS (1)</i>	<i>Greenpeace (2)</i>	<i>March of Dimes (3)</i>	<i>Contrasts</i>
Integrity	2,373	64.6	< .001	4.13	3.03	4.04	1&2, 2&3
Ruggedness	2,373	43.5	< .001	2.19	2.83	1.84	1&2, 3; 2&3
Sophistication	2,373	10.2	< .001	2.61	2.22	2.17	1&2; 3
Nurturance	2,373	42.9	< .001	3.22	2.81	3.92	1&2, 3; 2&3

a. Wilks's lambda = .419, $F = 50.39$, $p < .000$.

b. All univariate F values and Bonferroni contrasts were significantly different at alpha = .05.

c. We evaluated each brand personality dimension using an average scale score of the items contained in that dimension (see Table 4), where 1 = *not at all descriptive* and 5 = *very descriptive*.

respondent was randomly selected by asking for the adult (18 or older) whose birthday was the most recent; and (2) at least five callback attempts were made for each active number. Each respondent was asked about his or her awareness of the three nonprofit organizations and was assigned to one of the organizations that he or she recognized.

Reliability. We calculated construct reliability estimates on the basis of the standardized loadings for the four-factor correlated model (Fornell and Larker 1981). Coefficient alpha reliability estimates are summarized in Table 6. The corresponding construct reliability estimates were .92 for integrity, .75 for ruggedness, .72 for sophistication, and .88 for nurturance. In addition, all indicator t values were significant ($p < .001$), and all standardized estimates exceeded .50 (Hair et al. 1998).

Discriminant validity. We examined discriminant validity by a test that Fornell and Larker (1981) suggested in which the variance extracted within constructs is compared with the square of the bivariate correlation between factors. The variance-extracted statistics for the constructs in our model were .70 for integrity, .42 for ruggedness, .46 for sophisticated, and .71 for nurturing. The square of the phi estimates (which reflects the correlation between constructs) was as follows: (1) less than .01 between integrity and rugged, (2) .02 between rugged and nurturing, (3) .33 between rugged and sophisticated, (4) .13 between sophisticated and nurturing, (5) .19 between integrity and sophisticated, and (6) .66 between integrity and nurturing. Thus, all variance-extracted estimates exceeded the square of the between-factor correlations, providing evidence of discriminant validity. We used another method, which Anderson and Gerbing (1988) suggested, to assess the discriminant validity of the constructs. In this method, the covariance between two latent constructs is set to one, and the model is evaluated against a similar model without this constraint. We used this method to test the discriminant validity between integrity and nurturance. Comparing the fit between the two models (with the phi estimate between integrity and nurturing either set to one or allowed to be

TABLE 6
**Reliability and Standardized Loadings:
 Confirmatory Factor Analysis for Study 6^{a,b}**

<i>Construct</i>	<i>Item</i>	<i>Item Loading</i>
Integrity $\alpha = .922$	Honest	.86
	Positive influence	.84
	Committed to the public good	.84
	Reputable	.82
	Reliable	.81
Ruggedness $\alpha = .749$	Tough	.70
	Masculine	.68
	Outdoor	.61
	Western	.61
Sophistication $\alpha = .724$	Good-looking	.75
	Glamorous	.68
	Upper class	.59
Nurturance $\alpha = .876$	Compassionate	.87
	Caring	.84
	Loving	.82

a. $\chi^2 = 370.3$ with 84 degrees of freedom ($p < .001$) with a sample size of 1,029.

b. Goodness-of-Fit Index = .947, Incremental Fit Index = .962, and Comparative Fit Index = .962.

free) provided further evidence of discriminant validity ($\chi^2_{\Delta} = 12.25$ with 1 df , $p < .01$). Finally, none of the phi values (the covariances between constructs) plus or minus two standard errors included 1.0, providing further evidence of discriminant validity.

Overall model fit. In an effort to evaluate the scale items and their structure further, we examined a series of confirmatory factor models in Study 6. We evaluated a four-factor model (integrity, ruggedness, sophistication, and nurturance) with the 15 items that remained after Studies 4 and 5. We modeled all items to load on their corresponding factor and allowed all latent variables to correlate. Dimension labels, reliability estimates, items, and factor loadings appear in Table 6.

The chi-square value for this model was 370.3 with 84 degrees of freedom ($p < .001$). Values for the Goodness-of-Fit Index, Incremental Fit Index, and Comparative Fit

Index were .947, .962, and .962, respectively, indicating an acceptable level of fit. Although no absolute cutoff value or threshold value exists for interpreting these statistics, a cutoff value of .90 is frequently used in the literature (Bollen 1989; Hair et al. 1998). The root mean square error of approximation was .060, which is a goodness-of-fit measure that accounts for model complexity; values of .08 or lower indicate an adequate level of fit. In short, the four-factor model appeared to fit the data relatively well.

Alternative models. We examined several additional models to determine the dimensional structure of our data better. We estimated all models using AMOS 4.0 and compared them with the four-factor model we described previously; we allowed all latent variables to correlate. We estimated the models in the following order. First, we examined a one-dimensional model for which all items were forced to load as indicators on a single factor. Second, we examined a four-factor uncorrelated model, along with a three-factor model, with (1) ruggedness, (2) sophistication, (3) integrity, and (4) nurturance. Finally, we estimated an additional (four-factor alternative) model to assess the discriminant validity between integrity and nurturance. As we described previously, this model was identical to the four-factor correlated model, except that the covariance between integrity and nurturance was set to one.

All models exhibited a significant denigration in model fit when compared with the correlated four-factor model. Chi-square difference tests between that model and the alternative models were as follows: for the one-factor model, $\chi^2_{\Delta} = 1,826.5$ with 6 degrees of freedom; for the orthogonal four-factor model, $\chi^2_{\Delta} = 1,026.2$ with 6 degrees of freedom; for the three-factor model, $\chi^2_{\Delta} = 438.2$ with 3 degrees of freedom; and for the four-factor alternative model with integrity and nurturance set to one, $\chi^2_{\Delta} = 12.2$ with 1 degree of freedom. All of the chi-square difference tests were significant at $p < .01$, indicating a significantly worse fit to the data than the correlated four-factor model. Thus, all models exhibited some denigration of model fit when compared with the correlated four-factor model.

Predictive validity. We examined the predictive validity of the four factors of brand personality for nonprofit organizations (integrity, sophistication, ruggedness, and nurturance) by relating the factors to the likelihood that a person would contribute to a nonprofit organization. We combined the three measures of likelihood to contribute (money, time, and in-kind goods or services) to form a summated scale for each organization. The specific items used were as follows: "On a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 means *not very likely* and 5 means *very likely*, how likely is it that you will, (a) contribute any personal time, (b) contribute any money, (c) contribute something other than money or time?" Each respondent was asked these questions for one organization (PBS, Greenpeace, or March of Dimes) to minimize respondent fatigue. Alpha coefficients for the

likelihood of contributing scale were .74 for PBS, .86 for Greenpeace, and .78 for March of Dimes.

The overall correlation between likelihood to contribute and each dimension of nonprofit brand personality for each organization (PBS, Greenpeace, and March of Dimes, respectively) was as follows: .258, .432, and .301 for integrity; .274, .106, and .229 for sophistication; .236, .104, and .184 for ruggedness; and .268, .392, and .271 for nurturance. All the coefficients were significant at $p < .01$, except for the correlations for Greenpeace between sophistication ($r = .106$) and ruggedness ($r = .104$) and the likelihood to contribute to this organization. This result might be due to a perceived lack of connection between sophistication and the image of Greenpeace and a lack of variance on the ruggedness dimension for this organization. Thus, likelihood to contribute was related to respondents' perceptions of the organizations' brand personality, in support of the validity of our scale.

In summary, the confirmatory analysis supported the four-factor correlated solution in which integrity, sophistication, ruggedness, and nurturance served as the dimensions of brand personality among nonprofit organizations.

DISCUSSION AND IMPLICATIONS

This research extends the conceptualization and measurement of brand personality to the nonprofit sector. We attempted to answer four key questions that pertained to nonprofit brand personality: (1) Do nonprofit organizations possess brand personalities? (2) If they do, what kind of personalities are they? (3) Are nonprofit brand personalities related the charitable giving intentions? and (4) How can brand personalities help nonprofit marketers? The first three questions relate to the theoretical and measurement applicability of brand personality. The last question relates to the managerial relevance of our findings.

Implications for Theory

We asked the first question simply to determine whether the concept of brand personality applied to the nonprofit context. Thus, we conducted three qualitative studies to determine whether current and potential donors could indeed ascribe personality characteristics to nonprofit organizations. Our results reveal that this was the case. Indeed, respondents easily ascribed human personality traits to nonprofit organizations in both the qualitative and the quantitative phases of our research.

For our second question, the qualitative research provided a rich understanding of the personality characteristics that current and potential donors use to describe nonprofits. Here, we discovered that many of the dimensions used to describe the nonprofit organizations are similar to those previously found for consumer brands (J. L. Aaker

1997). However, new words emerged in this phase that validated the theoretical underpinnings of social exchange and trust that are central to the nonprofit context. Words such as *kind*, *caring*, and *compassionate* emerged, which reflect the social benefits that donors might seek from nonprofit organizations. Furthermore, the importance of trust emerged in terms of integrity and reliability. Here, words and descriptions such as *reputable*, *committed to the public good*, and *financially stable* all emerged from our series of qualitative studies.

In our quantitative phase, two of the four dimensions (sophistication and ruggedness) were similar to those previously found by Jennifer Aaker (1997). However, two additional dimensions, integrity and nurturance, were also established, which again provides relevance to the theoretical underpinnings of social exchange and trust in the nonprofit context. Integrity, which was the first factor in our quantitative exploratory analysis, represents a particularly important or chronic dimension for evaluating nonprofits. Integrity captures the importance that respondents place on commitment and reliability, as well as the positive influence that a nonprofit has on its community. This finding demonstrates the importance that people place on trust and public stewardship when they evaluate nonprofit organizations. Nurturance demonstrates the social benefits that current and potential donors search for in nonprofit organizations.

Overall, our results indicate that there are both similarities and differences between the brand personalities of nonprofit organizations and consumer brands. The emergence of integrity and nurturance as dimensions represent two important aspects of evaluating the brand personality of nonprofit organizations. Previous studies of brand personality have found several dimensions in different samples (J. L. Aaker 1997, 2000; Aaker et al. 2001; Ferrandi et al. 2000). Sincerity is the most commonly found dimension, followed by sophistication (see Table 1). Several other dimensions (e.g., ruggedness, J. L. Aaker 1997; robustness, Ferrandi et al. 2000; peacefulness, Aaker et al. 2001) have emerged in specific studies. Our findings build on this research by demonstrating the importance of sophistication and ruggedness among nonprofits. Although we did not explicitly find sincerity to be a dimension, integrity may encompass a more generalized form of trust or unique aspect of sincerity among nonprofits. Both sincerity and integrity include honesty as a trait. However, integrity appears to focus more on the overall commitment, positive influence, and reliability of a nonprofit organization, whereas sincerity focuses on a brand's wholeness and cheerfulness as well as its honesty. Thus, integrity is an important and unique dimension of brand personality found for nonprofits.

Although integrity was the first factor we studied across all three nonprofit classifications, the environmental organizations (i.e., Greenpeace; see Table 5) were not

perceived as possessing integrity to the same degree as the other two classifications. This finding reveals two important implications. First, not only do current and potential donors ascribe personality traits to nonprofit organizations but they also perceive differences in personalities across various types of nonprofits. Second, knowledge of this aspect of brand personality could prove useful for politically charged organizations, such as Greenpeace and the National Rifle Association.

It is not surprising that nurturance (compassion, loving, and caring) is a particularly salient brand personality dimension for nonprofit organizations across the three classifications (health, environment/rights, and arts/humanities). However, as we found in the integrity dimension, the degree of importance that people placed on nurturance when describing the organizations was not the same across the classifications (see Table 5). In other words, the mean difference for nurturance was lower for Greenpeace than for PBS or March of Dimes. Thus, brand personality dimensions vary not only among different samples (e.g., cultures, subcultures) but also according to the marketing context. This finding again may allude to the politically charged orientation of Greenpeace. Additional research should be conducted in other marketing contexts, such as services or tourist destinations, political candidates, educational institutions, or any number of venues.

With regard to our third question, the results shed some initial insight into the ability of nonprofit brand personalities to influence intent to give. Across the three nonprofit organizations (PBS, Greenpeace, and March of Dimes), we found significant correlations between each dimension of nonprofit brand personality and intent to give. Thus, this finding presents a starting point for further investigation of the relationship between nonprofit brand personality and important nonprofit outcomes. We discuss the implication of this finding further in the Future Research section.

Implications for Nonprofit Practitioners

With regard to our fourth question, brand personality has several implications for practitioners in the field of nonprofit marketing. Overall, it appears that brand personality can enhance the image of nonprofit organizations by enabling them to harness the power of branding. That is, nonprofit organizations can use brand personality to create a more specific and unique image by clearly communicating their personality dimensions.

Not only did this study indicate that across nonprofit classifications (health, environment/rights, and arts/humanities), there are distinct personality differences, but it also introduced the possibility that even within a classification (e.g., health), there may be opportunities for nonprofits to position themselves more strongly against their closest competitors. A clearer understanding of their own brand personality dimensions offers nonprofits the poten-

tial to capitalize on these nuances by developing and implementing branding strategies across key stakeholder groups. For example, all potential donors may be concerned with integrity and nurturance dimensions, but among professional nonprofit practitioners, integrity may be even more important because of their concerns with accountability. These insights may result in better targeted messages and media placement when nonprofits address different stakeholder groups. Thus, development of a strong brand personality may provide an efficient means to position a nonprofit organization both within and across market segments as it struggles with the increasing competition for donors.

The results of this study demonstrate the importance of focusing on several aspects of brand personality that differ from for-profit consumer brands. Nonprofits need to recognize the importance of developing a corporate identity that focuses on nurturance, or being perceived as caring and compassionate toward their cause. In addition, nonprofits cannot ignore the importance of integrity. Nonprofits must recognize their responsibility not only to be committed to the public good but also to be honest and forthright with how they ask for and handle donors' time, money, and in-kind donations, because people evaluate their actions and intentions.

LIMITATIONS

As with all social science research, it is important to recognize the limitations of this project. This research represents an initial attempt to extend brand personality measurement to the nonprofit sector. The specific organizations we used as stimuli in this project represent a potential limitation. Although we varied the organizations across studies and selected them for their familiarity and representativeness, the size and complexity of the nonprofit sector necessitates that the stimuli may not be representative of all nonprofit organizations. Future research could examine the brand personality of other nonprofits in additional classification categories.

The specific samples obtained and the sampling methods used represent another potential limitation to the findings. In an effort to understand better how people perceive and describe nonprofit organizations, in the initial qualitative research, we used convenience samples of students, community members, and practitioners. We also conducted preliminary quantitative studies among two separate convenience samples. We selected the two samples (faculty/staff and students) to represent current and future donors and to provide some demographic divergence across samples. Although we triangulated data across samples and incorporated information obtained from previous research and the qualitative studies, the specific samples we used in the exploratory phase of our research focused on univer-

sity respondents in the southeast and thus may not be representative of individual donors in general.

The second and confirmatory phase of our quantitative research attempted to address this limitation by using a nationally representative sample patterned after Jennifer Aaker's (1997) study. However, the use of telephone interviews may have led to a sample composed of respondents who were more likely to be at home (despite repeated callbacks) and more highly involved in nonprofits than the population in general. Future research might examine barriers to participation among noncontributors. However, all our samples exhibited a relatively high level of involvement in nonprofit organizations.

Further research is also needed to demonstrate more definitively the impact of brand personality on contributions to nonprofit organizations. Although this study provides a preliminary association between brand personality and likelihood to contribute, additional research could vary the levels of specific brand personality dimensions to assess their effects on likelihood to contribute. This type of experimental approach would better demonstrate the relationship between brand personality and giving in the nonprofit sector and be less susceptible to the problem of common-method bias than the correlational approach we used in this study.

In short, despite the use of different methods and sample groups, this study is limited by the specific samples, the specific traits, and the specific organizations studied. Further exploration and description of key personality factors and terms to describe a broad array of organizations and situations are needed and are an important topic for future research.

FUTURE RESEARCH

The concept of brand personality in the nonprofit sector can be explored further in several ways. First, our measure of brand personality should be replicated in other nonprofit contexts for further validation. Different dimensions of brand personality have been found by Jennifer Aaker (1997, 1999) in her examination of brand personality in different cultures. Similarly, differences may occur across stakeholder groups and cultures when nonprofit brands are assessed. Future research could examine the specific characteristics of nonprofit donors and further test the efficacy and robustness of our measures among different samples and in different contexts.

Further research is also needed to demonstrate more definitively the impact of brand personality on contributions to nonprofit organizations. This study provides a preliminary association between brand personality and likelihood to contribute, but it does not directly examine the impact of brand personality on actual contributions over time. Future research could longitudinally track measures

of brand personality over time and directly link changes in the measures to changes in donations.

Multidimensional scaling and positioning studies could also determine the perceptual proximity of specific nonprofit categories and examples of nonprofit brands. Here, a nonprofit organization could learn the extent to which it occupies a unique competitive position and identify specific patterns of competition and contributions in its own category or across nonprofit categories.

Research could also experimentally manipulate the situational or message salience of specific brand personality dimensions and assess the effects of varying the accessibility and diagnosticity of various brand personality dimensions on a person's motivation to contribute (see J. L. Aaker 2000). Historical analysis examining the prominence of various themes in the advertisements of nonprofits over time would also be of interest.

As we mentioned previously, additional research could be conducted on nonprofit organizations' political orientation and its impact on brand personality. Because some nonprofits (e.g., National Rifle Association, Greenpeace, political parties) are more politically charged than others, it would be of interest to investigate how these organizations' personalities are perceived and whether dimensions such as integrity and nurturance help or hinder donations.

Research that links donor characteristics to perceptions of brand personality and contributions to nonprofit organizations is also needed. Studies could link demographic characteristics, values, and personality data to measures of brand personality and prior contributions to nonprofit organizations. The trust-oriented, social-exchange nature of the relationship between people and nonprofits should provide a worthwhile and fruitful context for examining the importance of self-brand congruence.

Additional research could also examine how personal-ity perceptions of nonprofit organizations are formed and shift over time. To what extent are people influenced by direct experience, advertising, and media portrayals? Qualitative research could attempt to explore this issue by longitudinally interviewing potential donors over time. Quantitative research could experimentally manipulate mock news articles and/or advertisements, assessing the impact of these stimuli on potential contributions. Finally, quasi-experimental methods that opportunistically examine the impact of specific events on specific organizations may also be of value.

CONCLUSION

Our study has attempted to integrate existing knowledge of brand personality in the for-profit sector with social exchange theory and trust to identify the specific dimensions of brand personality among nonprofit organizations. We conducted a series of six studies to investigate,

measure, and validate the role of brand personality in nonprofit organizations. Our multimethod design revealed a parsimonious measure of nonprofit brand personality that consists of four dimensions: integrity, sophistication, ruggedness, and nurturance. Thus, despite our aforementioned limitations, we extend brand personality research to nonprofit brands and establish that stakeholders can and do differentiate between nonprofits on the basis of brand personality.

Finally, this study offers potential new ways for nonprofit organizations to strengthen their brands and market position as they vie with competing organizations for donors' time, money, and in-kind goods or services. By recognizing that current and potential donors can view nonprofits as unique personalities, nonprofit organizations may be able to match their personality better with those of their target stakeholders and to differentiate themselves in the crowded nonprofit marketplace. Thus, nonprofit brand personality could prove invaluable in the brand development of nonprofit organizations.

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